

Diagnostic tests

If you've had a positive screening test for Down syndrome or another genetic abnormality, you will be offered a diagnostic test, which gives a definitive answer as to whether or not your baby has an abnormality.

What are diagnostic tests?

Diagnostic tests are tests that involve taking a sample of the placenta, the amniotic fluid, or fetal blood. The samples are then sent away and examined in a laboratory for chromosomal or genetic abnormalities. The two main diagnostic tests are amniocentesis and chorionic villus sampling, or CVS. Since both of these tests carry a small risk of miscarriage (see [A comparison between CVS and amniocentesis](#)), you will need to carefully consider the advantages and disadvantages of the tests before going ahead with either of them.

Chorionic villus sampling (CVS) Chorionic villi are fragments of placental tissue. Because the placenta originates from the fertilized egg, the chromosomes in the cells that make up the placenta are representative of your baby's chromosomes. During CVS, a small amount of tissue from your placenta is removed and tested in a laboratory to reveal if your baby has a chromosomal disorder such as Down syndrome or another trisomy disorder, such as Edwards or Patau syndrome. CVS is done between 11 and 14 weeks' gestation and the results are usually available within 7 to 10 days. The procedure can also definitely identify your baby's sex, if you want to know. If you don't want to have this information, make your wishes clear before the test. In rare cases, the doctor will be unable to perform CVS due to the placenta's position. In this case, you may be asked to return for an amniocentesis at 15 weeks.

CHORIONIC VILLUS SAMPLING

There are two ways of doing chorionic villus sampling. In the transabdominal method, a fine needle is placed through the abdomen to collect placental fragments. In the transcervical procedure, a thin tube (catheter) is inserted into the cervix. It is most usually performed using the transabdominal method. During the procedure, ultrasound guidance is used so that the doctor can see the placenta's position.

CVS can also be done in a multiple pregnancy; in this case both the transabdominal and transcervical methods of collection may be used.